



Music Review Guide

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Range: Check the Music chat you lazy bum

(Musical Periods (Middle Ages–Modern) & Instrumental Knowledge)

Note: Review Guides are UNOFFICIAL sources of reference and do NOT include or hint at questions in the actual exam! (Except this one because it's partly taken from the Music chat WuJianJing sent, so if it's not tested, it's his fault)

Part I: Historical Periods of Music

Middle Ages (ca. 500–1400)

- **Key word:** Dark
- **Context:** Dominated by the Church; music served religious rituals.
- **Style:**
 - *Monophony*: Single melodic line (e.g., Gregorian chant).
 - *Neumes*: Early notation (notation for Gregorian Chant)
- **Forms/Genres:**
 - *Plainchant (aka Gregorian chants)*: Sacred songs in Latin.
- **Key Composer:** Hildegard of Bingen — mystic nun, prolific composer.
- **Listening Focus:**
 - Chant-like quality
 - modal scales (Ionian, Dorian, Phrygian, Lydian, Mixolydian, Aeolian, Locrian)
 - lack of steady beat

Renaissance (ca. 1400–1600)

- **Key word:** humanism
- **Context:** rise of secularism, invention of the printing press.
- **Style:**
 - *Polyphony*: Interweaving independent lines.
 - *Word painting*: Music literally illustrates lyrics (e.g., “rise rise rise rise”, with each “rise” one semitone higher).
- **Genres:**
 - *Mass* (sacred): polyphonic (many voice simulatenously) or plainchant
 - *Motet* (sacred): choral composition, standalone piece, polyphonic, freer than Mass and not always for worship
 - *Madrigal* (secular): Vocal secular music
- **Key Composers:** Josquin des Prez (wrote motets), Palestrina (wrote mass)
- **Listening Focus:**

- Clarity of text
- Imitative textures: polyphonic texture where one voice or part imitates the melody of another voice or part, usually at a slightly later time
- Modal harmony: no structural harmony (like V-I), but still has tonal center (Mode)

Baroque (1600–1750)

- **Key word: absolutism**
 - **Context:** dramatic arts (drastic contrast in color; characters in bloody motion), Versailles = music center, Counter-Reformation
 - **Style:**
 - *Unity of mood:* maintaining constant emotional atmosphere
 - *Rhythmic drive:* strong sense of momentum, maintained usually by drums/bass
 - *Basso continuo:* continuous bassline played by one instrument (can change, vary)
 - *Terraced dynamics:* Abrupt shifts between loud/soft dynamics.
 - **Key Forms/Genres:**
 - *Fugue:* Musical structure, counterpoint with subject/answer/exposition/development/coda
 - *Concerto Grosso:* Dialogue between soloists (concertino) and orchestra (ripieno).
 - *Opera:* dramatic work/story with mostly singing and orchestral accompaniment
 - *Oratorio:* large-scale musical composition for orchestra, choir, and soloists
 - *Cantata:* vocal composition with instrumental accompaniment, sacred/secular
 - *Toccata:* free-flowing, improvisational, organ/harpsichord
 - **Key Composers:** J.S. Bach (famous for fugues), G.F. Handel (“Hallelujah” from Messiah), Vivaldi (four seasons), Monteverdi, Pachelbel (canon in d)
 - **Listening Focus:**
 - Harpsichord: piano, except strings are plucked
 - Ornamentation: additional, decorative elements (e.g. trills)
 - Continuous melody: Uninterrupted flow
 - Contrapuntal complexity: elaborate uses of counterpoints (two or more melodic lines at the same time)
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Classical (1750–1820)

- **Key word: enlightenment**
 - **Context:** Enlightenment ideals—balance, clarity, form.
 - **Style:**
 - *Homophony*: Melody with accompaniment (harmony).
 - *Balanced phrases*: musical structure with two or more phrases (musical sentences that convey ideas) of equal length and similar tension
 - *Simple harmony*: Two or more notes played together pleasingly, e.g. triads
 - *Clear cadences*: Cadence with clear conclusion (Authentic V-I, Plagal IV-I)
 - **Key Forms/Genres:**
 - *Sonata form*: Exposition – Development – Recapitulation.
 - *Symphony*: a large-scale musical composition for orchestra, fast-slow-dance-fast
 - *Concerto*: musical composition for one solo instrument
 - *String Quartet*: Two violins, a viola, a cello
 - *Zu 2*: 2 instruments play in unison
 - **Key Composers:** Haydn (father of string quartet and symphony), Mozart (prodigy, famous for his nine symphonies), early Beethoven
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Romantic (1820–1900)

- **Key word: individualism**
- **Context:** nationalism, Industrial Revolution.
- **Themes:**
 - Love, death, nature, the supernatural, exoticism.
- **Musical Features:**
 - *Program Music*: Tells a story (e.g., *Symphonie Fantastique*).
 - *Rubato*: speeds up/slows down time, overall duration intact
 - Expanded orchestration: increasing the orchestra size and types instruments
 - Virtuosity: extreme technical skill (e.g. Paganini and Liszt)
 - Self-expression: composers tried to express their inner feelings through the pieces of music they create
- **Key Composers:**

- Beethoven (late): lost hearing, much more romantic (e.g. he expressed his frustration through his music)
- Chopin: Polish, weak, wrote nocturnes (quiet, calm, beautiful pieces), “poet of the piano”
- Liszt: Pianist with big hands, handsome womaniser, plays difficult pieces for fun
- Berlioz: Unconventional music, fell in love and wrote Symphonie Fantastique (dude kills his love and goes to hell and meets her)
- Brahms: Conservative, German, friends ;) with Clara Schumann
- Tchaikovsky: Russian ballet master (Nutcracker, Swan Lake), gay
- Mendelssohn: Bach glazer, got advice from sister Fanny, died at 38 from overwork (bro is an SHSID student)
- Schubert: hard-working Beethoven glazer wrote Lied(er) (Art song, setting of poem to music, e.g. Erlking)
- Richard Wagner: Hungarian, Jew-hater, Hitler’s a fan, had Leitmotif (musical theme that suggests a person, idea, or event)
- Puccini: Italian, Verismo (operas that portrayed real people), La Boheme (real, difficult life of musicians, philosophers, playwrights...), soaring melodies
- **Listening Focus:** Rich harmonies, dynamic contrasts, expressive melodies, experimenting with dissonance

Modern Era & the “Isms” (1900–Present)

Context: Two world wars, technology, global influence, philosophical shifts.

Impressionism

- **Inspiration:** Claude Monet’s painting *Impression: Sunrise*.
- **Musical Traits:**
 - Whole-tone/pentatonic/modal scales.
 - Color and texture over clear form.
 - Extended chords (9ths, 13ths), floating rhythms.
- **Key Composers:** Claude Debussy (*Clair de Lune*), Maurice Ravel.

Primitivism

- **Inspiration:** Folk art, tribal rhythms, prehistoric themes.
- **Traits:**
 - Savage rhythms

- Ostinatos: short, repetitive musical phrases, typically in the same pitch or rhythm
- Polytonality: two or more keys/tonal centers used simultaneously
- Harsh dissonance: exactly what it sounds like
- Simple motives: Short, recognizable ideas (e.g. Mission Impossible theme)
- **Key Work:** Stravinsky's *The Rite of Spring* (Yinte likes this a lot)

Expressionism

- **Themes:** Inner anxiety, nightmares, alienation.
- **Traits:**
 - Atonality, extreme dissonance, Sprechstimme (spoken singing).
- **Key Composers:** Schoenberg, Berg, Webern.
- **Techniques:**
 - *Twelve-tone system:* Serialism using tone rows.

Minimalism

- **Traits:** Repetition, gradual change, steady pulse.
- **Composers:** Steve Reich (*Clapping Music*), Philip Glass.

Electronic & Chance (*Aleatoric, indeterminate*) Music

- **Traits:** Synthesizers, tape loops, ambient textures, chance (luck and randomness part of composition)
- **Figures:**
 - John Cage (*4'33"*): music professor, what is music?
 - Varese (*Poème électronique*): *Poème électronique* = electronic music pioneer
 - Kraftwerk: pioneered, electric-synth, techno, and electronic dance music

Part II: Instruments & Orchestra

Instrument Families

- **Strings:** Violin, viola, cello (violoncello), double bass, harp.
 - Played with bow (arco) or plucked (pizzicato).
- **Woodwinds:** Flute (flauto), oboe (oboi), clarinet (Bb), bassoon (Faggotti), contrabassoon
 - Tone produced via vibrating air column.

- **Brass:** Trumpet (Bb), French horn (F, written as C, Corni), trombone (trombe), tuba (C/Bb).
 - Lips buzz into a cup-shaped mouthpiece.
 - **Percussion:**
 - *Pitched:* Timpani, xylophone.
 - *Unpitched:* Snare drum, cymbals.
 - **Keyboards:** Piano (strings struck), organ, harpsichord.
 - **Electronic:** Synthesizers, samplers.
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The Orchestra

Structure & Seating:

- Strings front, woodwinds center, brass back, percussion rear.
- Modern orchestras often include over 90 musicians.

Evolution Highlights:

- **Baroque:** Small, harpsichord-centered ensembles.
- **Classical:** Balanced, with winds used in pairs, less bass
- **Romantic:** Larger, with added instruments (tuba, cymbals, harp) and expanded size of existing parts of the orchestra
- **Modern:** Expanded percussion, exotic instruments, electronics.

Examples:

- *Haydn's Symphony No. 31* (Classical)
- *Wagner's Ride of the Valkyries* (Romantic)
- *Stravinsky's The Rite of Spring* (Modern)

Part III: Transposing

1. Understand the key of the instrument
 - a. Bb: Clarinet, trumpet, cornet (when they see a C on the score, it's actually a Bb when they blow it out)
 - b. F: French horn, English horn (P5 lower), Alto Clarinet
 - c. Eb: Alto (M6 lower) + Baritone Sax (M6+P8 lower), Eb Clarinet (m3 higher)
 - d. G: Alto flute (P4 lower)

2. Find the interval between the key and concert pitch (C)
3. Move all notes in the piece by that interval
4. Adjust the key signature based on your new transposed key

